

Spread of the Renaissance

From the end of the 15th century, the Renaissance spread from Italy to other parts of Europe and a Northern Renaissance emerged. Northern countries, particularly the Netherlands and Germany, produced their own great artists, such as Albrecht Dürer (1471–1528) and Hans Holbein the Younger (1497–1543)—both gifted realists. Renaissance Humanism also spread northward, but northern writers and philosophers, most notably Erasmus of Rotterdam (1466–1536), tended to place more emphasis on Christianity, education, and reform than their Italian counterparts.

The invention of printing using movable type by Johannes Gutenberg in Germany in the 1430s enabled Renaissance ideas to spread even more quickly. Before Gutenberg, the only way printed text was possible was for each page to be carved by hand into a block of wood, but as this was so laborious books were invariably written out by hand. Gutenberg's method involved arranging individual metal letters and punctuation symbols in lines and pages; when many copies of a page had been printed, the type could be taken apart and reused. He combined this new idea with the existing technology of paper-making and the kind of press used in wine production, and the result was the printing of multiple copies of books for the first time.

Gutenberg's invention had a major impact. It meant that books, which had previously been costly and took months to produce, were now easily available and much more affordable, so ideas and information could circulate quickly and reach more people. While the church had used mostly Latin as its universal language, writers now wrote in their local tongues, and as a result literature in French, English, German, and other languages flourished. In addition, copies of the ancient classics were reproduced in quantity, thus helping spread ideas that were central to both the Renaissance and Humanism.

The Renaissance's impact

By the mid-16th century, the influence of the Renaissance was waning in southern Europe, but it lasted slightly longer in the north. However, many great Renaissance works endured and they continued to inspire future generations of painters and architects. Indeed, the long-standing popularity of oil paintings and classical style of architecture, and the rise of Humanism, would all have been impossible without the movement that began with Brunelleschi in Florence in the 15th century. ■



Filippo Brunelleschi

Born in Florence, Filippo Brunelleschi (1377–1446) was the son of a civil servant, who educated Filippo in the hope that he would follow in his footsteps. However, Filippo was artistically talented and instead trained as a goldsmith and a clockmaker before becoming an architect. When he was around 25, he traveled to Rome with his friend, the sculptor Donatello, where he studied the remains of ancient Roman buildings and read the treatise *On Architecture* by the Roman writer Vitruvius. In 1419, he won his first major commission—the design of an orphanage, the Ospedale degli Innocenti in Florence, which, with its arched loggia, is one of the first great Renaissance buildings. A number of other fine works, including chapels in Florentine churches and fortifications for the city, cemented his reputation, but the stunning dome of Il Duomo is his masterpiece. In addition to his buildings, Brunelleschi did important work on the theory of linear perspective, and designed machinery to produce special effects in theatrical productions.